

FINE LIVING
RESTAURANT

A SLICE OF HEAVEN

Feast on stories of Varanasi at Aangan, over an all-vegetarian, 10-course degustation menu that promises a history lesson.

Chumki Bharadwaj

"Tourists usually travel to experience life; but people come to Benaras to die," proffers our 20-something-year-old server, somewhat sagely as he ladles out the palak paneer. Impromptu existential wisdom served over lunch from Gen Z wait staff at a 214-year-old palace-hotel is just one of the many anachronisms that make Varanasi endlessly fascinating. The majestic BrijRama Palace that piles up lofty over the dancing Ganga, is a poetic example of this unity of opposites.

A former seat of the erstwhile king of Darbhanga, this heritage property recently launched its new signature restaurant, Aangan, which serves a Michelin-worthy, 10-course set vegetarian menu that weaves together a historical narrative of the passage of time. This multi-sensory immersive journey celebrates the region's royal legacy, with each creation crafted as a lyrical paean to the traditions of three storied guardians of the palace.

Literally meaning 'courtyard', this was the venue that played host to the erstwhile king of Darbhanga, where he used to watch classical musical performances. The elegant decor does its memories proud by wearing its vintage patina with élan; while the ten-course degustation menu preys on memory and metaphor to celebrate local and seasonal ingredients with contemporary flair.